

THE UGLY POLI

alone. There are a few others who excel in political harlotry in the name of social justice

■ By S. Prasannarajan

Once upon a time in India ruled a prime minister called Haradanahalli Doddegowda Deve Gowda, the most favoured farmer after Charan Singh in the mutative history of the Janata experiment. His migration, semaphored by a lucky constellation of stars in the southern sky, from the fertile farmlands of Karnataka politics to the treacherous heart of Delhi, marked the lowest point in the politics of alternatives. There he was, the prime minister as a peasant in perpetual passivity with the weltanschauung of a panchayat president. The farce of those nine months in the 1990s further magnified the hollowness of the much marketed anti-elitism of that tag line: I'm a humble farmer. Such manufactured modesty was only a cover for his vulpine project in power, whose ultimate source for the most provincial of prime ministers was his home state of Karnataka: Delhi was subordinated to Holenarsipur. In retrospect, perhaps he only wanted to be an ex-prime minister; that inglorious tenure in South Block was a national interlude in a life enriched by the harvest of rural caste politics in southern remoteness. He would return to more infamies of the politics of family farming—to be at home.

Today, as Gowda looms over the ruins of a coalition Government in Karnataka—as father most capricious and wrecker most ruthless—his worst farming instincts are on display once more. The betrayed BJP, whose suicidal mistake was to enter into a power-sharing agreement with the Gowda family enterprise, should have seen it coming. Follow the sequence and you want to be shocked by the grotesquery of the G factor but you can't—the Gowdas have made it commonplace. It begins with son Kumaraswamy's first act of sabotage as a partner; he brings down the Congress-led government and forms an incompatible but convenient alliance with BJP to become chief minister for the first half of the tenure. Father basks in dynastic glow as son expands the family domain. When BJP's turn for chief ministership comes as per the agreement, the son hesitates, the government falls and Central rule comes into force. Wilderness is something even seasoned farmers find hard to endure, particularly when the season is ideal for cash crops. So the agreement is revived and BJP's Yeddyurappa becomes chief minister. The Gowdas want to be rewarded appropriately, which means all the plum

